

The French Revolution

1750–1900

In the late 18th century, a revolution began in France that would lead to dramatic changes in society. In this violent period, the French people overthrew the monarchy before executing its members, and replaced it with a new type of government that pushed to give people greater freedom and equality.

In 1789, the gap between rich and poor in French society was huge. King Louis XVI and the aristocracy, who paid no taxes, held all of the political power as well as most of the wealth. At the same time, a series of bad harvests had led to food shortages and the price of basic essentials such as bread rose so high that many poor people—who were forced to pay taxes—couldn't afford it.

The people's anger built toward a king who didn't seem to care about his people. By June 1789, the people

claimed power by forming a National Assembly (a government by the common people), which demanded more rights, but when the king failed to give it his support violence erupted on the streets of Paris.

Desperation pushed the French people toward the abolition of their monarchy much sooner than any other country in Europe. The revolution's slogan—"Liberty, equality, fraternity!"—summed up what they were fighting for, and this remains the motto of France today.

▼ RIGHTS OF MAN

The Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen was published in 1789 and expressed the aims of the new revolutionary government. The document stated that all men were equal under the law. Despite protests, the declaration was not amended to give women these same rights.



STORMING THE BASTILLE

In July 1789, rumors that the king planned to shut down the National Assembly enraged Parisians. On the 14th, they stormed the Bastille, a royal fortress and prison, and freed seven prisoners held captive there. The revolution had started. This day is celebrated in France each year as Bastille Day.

